same time, we believe he does not want to weaken them so much that they cannot be used as an Indian lever against the government in Colombo in the future. New Delhi therefore almost certainly will remain open to the possibility of resuming a political dialogue with the tigers. Over the long term, we believe Gandhi anticipates he can extract Indian troops from their difficult peacekeeping mission after implementing the accord. There would be more widespread outbreaks of violence between Tamils and Sinahalese, and India may conclude there is little chance to settle the Island's ethnic problem. Gandhi would then begin to look for face-saving ways to withdraw Indian troops, possibly arguing that India faced more compelling national security threats such as

renewed tensions on the Indo-Pakistan or Indo-Chinese border.

The complete withdrawal of the IPKF from Sri Lankan soil was indeed a face saving move, but one that was made by Gandhi's successor V.P. Singh, who won the 1989 elections promising a corruption free government.

But the planning in 2006 was different. The R&AW had learnt from the mistakes of 1987 and both human intelligence (HUMINT) and technical intelligence (TECHINT) used their assets to defeat the mighty Tigers. According to Arora, the Sri Lanka army would have been completely blinded without the support of the R&AW. The Indian agency, however, had to quietly bear the loss of four assets who were recruited to continue providing HUMINT.

'It was not LTTE alone that killed our assets,' said Arora. 'We later learnt that the Sri Lankan army had also been involved in hitting our informers. Just before the final and massive offensive in April 2009, some important assets were evacuated